The Noisy Wagon

Lark & Nib's Treasure Quest · Season 1, Episode 7

The ferry was tied behind you. Ahead, a dry bank curved toward the meadow on your newest map section. Nib pulled the wagon slowly along it. The protected map, mat, journal, and explorer case rode safely inside.

A little clatter followed every turn of the wheel.

Nib stopped. The clatter stopped.

He took one more step. Clatter.

On a fixed branch beyond the path rested a nest. A small bird slept inside, its beak tucked into its feathers.

Nib lifted one paw and began an extremely careful tiptoe. The wagon answered with an extremely ordinary rattle.

“I am being exceptionally quiet,” Nib whispered earnestly.

“Your wagon has another opinion,” Lark murmured gently.

She looked beneath the handle. A metal fitting was still attached to the frame, but its free edge knocked against the wood. Nib's feet were not the problem. The fitting needed a fastener.

Lark parked the wagon before the nest. There was room to work without touching the branch.

“We can mend the rattle here,” Lark explained softly. “Then the wagon can be quiet, too.”

First she opened the journal to your ink-box page. She showed sit, then sat.

“Listen to the middle of sit,” Lark invited gently. “Which of these two words has our short i? You can sound them out.”

Nib nudged his nose toward the tool kit. Two matching pockets were closed inside it. Their labels had three little letters each.

Lark drew a line down, another up, and a small arch back down beside it.

“This is lowercase n,” Lark explained clearly. “Put your tongue just behind your top teeth and let your voice hum through your nose: /n/. For m, your lips close. For n, your tongue goes up. Listen to both, then find n.”

“Nest. Nap. Nib,” Nib counted quietly. “A useful beginning.”

Lark placed i beside n. She slid their sounds together into in. With p at the beginning, the word grew into pin.

“In. Pin,” Lark modeled softly. “Join the two sounds, then all three. Our little fastener has a name we can read.”

Nib held the loose fitting against the frame. It stayed quiet beneath his paw, but he could not walk while holding it there.

Lark drew the wagon on a fresh journal page, leaving room for its new letter.

“Write n beside the wheel,” Lark invited warmly. “Down, back up, and over one little arch. You can follow my first mark.”

The two tool pockets faced you. One said pin. The other said tin. Neither was larger or brighter than its neighbor.

“Which pocket has the fastener we need?” Lark asked gently. “Read the beginning as well as the ending. You can ask for a sound if you need one.”

Inside the pin pocket were the small fastening clips packed with your folios. Lark brought one to the fitting. Nib kept the metal edge still.

“The opening is here,” Lark explained calmly. “Clip the fitting to the frame while Nib holds it.”

The clip closed with a little settling click. Nib lifted his paw. The fitting stayed against the wood.

Lark rolled the wagon a short way. Its wheel turned. The case rode smoothly. No clatter followed.

“Now we are both being quiet,” Nib breathed proudly.

The crew passed the nest on the dry path. The bird shifted its feathers, settled more comfortably, and stayed asleep. Nobody needed to touch the nest or creep beneath it.

At the meadow edge, Lark drew Nib tiptoeing beside a wagon with its fitting held tight.

“What stopped the rattle?” Lark asked gently. “Did we change Nib's feet, or did we fasten the loose metal?”

Nib inspected the portrait.

“A remarkably quiet drawing,” Nib whispered approvingly.

The pin stayed on the wagon. Spare clips returned to the kit. Your map still had one empty space, and the meadow was bright ahead.

A red ribbon fluttered from an old post between two animal carvings. This time Nib let the wagon roll to a quiet stop before he hurried to investigate.